

Latvia

Ratio: 1:2 **Adopted:** February 27, 1990 **Usage:** National and Civil

Red recalls the blood shed by the wounded leader



White may stand for the sheet used to wrap the wounded Latvian leader

Red also represents Latvians' willingness to defend their liberty

Europe



Over the centuries, **Latvia** has been invaded by Swedes, Poles, and Russians. It became independent from the Soviet Union in 1991.

Though officially adopted in 1922, the Latvian flag was in use as early as the 13th century, but its use was suppressed during Soviet rule.

The red color is sometimes described as symbolizing the readiness of the Latvians to give the blood from their hearts for freedom. An alternative interpretation, according

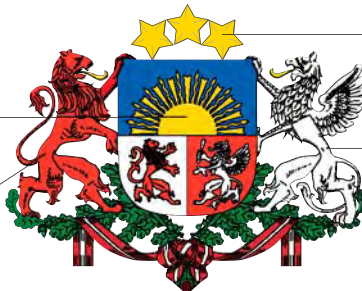
to one legend, is that a Latvian leader was wounded in battle, and the edges of the white sheet in which he was wrapped were stained by his blood.

The coat of arms depicts a tripartite shield recalling the three reunited duchies of Latvia. The shield is held by a red lion and a silver griffin.

ARMS OF LATVIA

Rising sun represents the Duchy of Latgale

The red lion represents the Duchy of Kurzeme



Three stars for the reunited duchies

The silver griffin recalls the Duchy of Vidzeme